

LESSON 6 · ART SCHOOL, BUT DIY

Color Fundamentals

How color works, how colors relate to each other, and how to use them with intention.

Overview

Color is the most emotionally immediate element of any artwork. Before you can use it expressively, you need to understand its underlying structure. Color theory isn't a set of rules — it's a map. It describes how colors relate to each other, how light affects them, and which combinations tend to work and why.

The greatest mistake beginners make with color is treating it separately from value. They get the hue right but the value wrong, and the drawing collapses. The first principle of good color work: *get the values right first*. If your painting reads well in grayscale, color will enhance it. If it fails in grayscale, no amount of beautiful color will save it.

CORE CONCEPTS

The Three Dimensions of Color

Hue: The color's position on the spectrum (red, orange, yellow, green, blue, violet). This is what most people mean when they say "color."

Value: The lightness or darkness of the color, independent of hue. Yellow is inherently high-value; violet is inherently low-value. Changing the value of a hue changes its character completely.

Saturation (Chroma): The intensity or purity of the hue. A fully saturated red is vivid and intense; a desaturated red approaches gray. Most colors in nature are desaturated — pure saturated colors are rare and draw immediate attention.

The Color Wheel

The color wheel organizes hues by their relationships. **Primary colors** (red, blue, yellow in traditional pigment theory; or red, green, blue in light) cannot be mixed from other colors. **Secondary colors** are mixes of two primaries. **Tertiary colors** are mixes of a primary and an adjacent secondary.

Color Harmonies

Complementary: Colors directly opposite on the wheel (red/green, blue/orange, yellow/violet). Maximum contrast — vibrant and intense when placed next to each other. Use one as dominant, the other as accent.

Analogous: Colors adjacent on the wheel (red, red-orange, orange). Harmonious and natural-feeling. Low contrast but cohesive. Often used for atmospheric and environmental color schemes.

Triadic: Three colors equally spaced around the wheel. Vibrant and balanced — provides variety without the tension of complementary pairs.

Split-Complementary: One hue plus the two colors adjacent to its complement. Less tense than a full complementary pair, with more variety than analogous.

Color Temperature

Colors have temperature: reds, oranges, and yellows are warm; blues, greens, and violets are cool. This is not just emotional — it has real optical effects. Warm colors appear to advance (come forward in space); cool colors appear to recede. In natural light, lit areas are often warm and shadow areas cool (or vice versa). Using temperature contrast in your shading creates luminous, convincing light.

Limited Palette Thinking

Working with fewer colors forces you to mix deliberately and creates natural color harmony. A limited palette of 3–4 colors can produce a stunning range through mixing, and because all the colors share pigments, they automatically harmonize. Start every color study with a limited palette before expanding.

DAILY EXERCISES

EXERCISE 1

Build a Color Wheel

- Using any medium (pencil, watercolor, colored pencils, or digital), build a 12-hue color wheel.
- Place the three primaries first (evenly spaced at 120 degrees). Mix secondaries between them. Then fill in tertiaries.
- Below each hue, create a desaturation gradient from full saturation to neutral gray.
- Keep this wheel as a reference for all color work in this lesson.

EXERCISE 2**Value-First Color Study**

- Find a colorful reference photo. Convert it to grayscale (phone camera B&W; mode works fine).
- Study the grayscale version for 5 minutes — identify the 5 value zones.
- Now paint the color version, but match each area's value to what you identified in the grayscale.
- The goal: your color painting should read identically to the grayscale when converted back.

EXERCISE 3**Color Harmony Swatches**

- Using Adobe Color (color.adobe.com — free tool), select a base hue.
- Generate four harmony types: complementary, analogous, triadic, split-complementary.
- For each harmony, paint a small color study of a simple object (a sphere or mug).
- Note the emotional difference between each scheme — which feels tense, serene, vibrant, or flat?

CURATED FREE RESOURCES

Blender Guru — Understanding Coloryoutube.com/watch?v=HNgK0H9ZVZE · Video

One of the most-watched free color theory tutorials online. Covers hue, value, saturation, and harmony with clear visuals.

James Gurney — Color and Light (YouTube Channel)youtube.com/@JamesGurney · Video Channel

Author of Color and Light shares daily painting demonstrations and lighting analysis. An invaluable ongoing resource.

Adobe Color — Free Interactive Color Wheelcolor.adobe.com · Tool

The best free color tool online. Explore complementary, analogous, triadic, and split-complementary schemes in real time.

Proko — Color Theory Fundamentalsyoutube.com/@Proko · Video

Beginner-friendly coverage of the color wheel, value relationships, and how to build a limited palette.

Sinix Design — Colors That Workyoutube.com/@sinixdesign · Video

Practical guide to color harmony, limited palettes, and color relationships in real artwork.

Tyler Edlin Art — Color Temperature Deep Diveyoutube.com/@TylerEdlinArt · Video

Focused exploration of warm vs. cool temperature — essential for understanding light and painting convincing scenes.

Sarah Renae Clark — Color Theory for Artistsyoutube.com/@sarahrenae · Video Series

Beginner-friendly series explaining color theory in plain terms for traditional and digital artists.

Color-Wheel-Artist.com — Mixing Guidecolor-wheel-artist.com · Article / Guide

Comprehensive free written guide to color mixing, pigment properties, and traditional palette setup.

Ctrl+Paint — Color & Value Relationshipctrlpaint.com/topics/color · Course

Free library section on how value and color interact in realistic painting.

Krita — Free Digital Painting App

krita.org/en/download · Tool (Free)

Professional free digital software. Use it to explore color harmony exercises alongside traditional study.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

Every day: One small color study — any subject, any medium. Focus on getting the value structure right before worrying about hue.

Weekly: Paint the same simple subject four times using four different color harmonies. Compare the emotional result of each.